

Freemasonry: Secret Handshakes And Suspicion [C1]

Con la sua aura di mistero, i suoi simboli e i suoi rituali, la massoneria continua a suscitare molte domande tra chi non fa parte di questo mondo. Proviamo a rispondere ad alcune di esse.

Founded in London in 1717 as a [fellowship](#) designed to [bind](#) men around a set of [high-minded](#) ideals, [Freemasonry](#) rapidly spread across the globe — from the young United States under the [presidency](#) of George Washington to the British Empire, and Napoleonic France. But influence was accompanied by fear and persecution. In the eyes of the Catholic Church, Freemasons were a [den](#) of [devil-worshippers](#). For Hitler, Mussolini and Franco, Freemasons represented the epitome of the internal enemy, accused of spreading the ‘diseases’ of pacifism and socialism. Indeed, Freemasons themselves present their history as a noble tradition of brotherhood, [Enlightenment](#) values and charity, while for outsiders they are often seen as a network of insiders who use secret [handshakes](#) to obtain favours, conspire to [secure](#) jobs and infiltrate [ruling elites](#). It is understandable that many Freemasons [get annoyed](#) at the suggestion that there is anything sinister or corrupt about their organisation. But it is also understandable that the [oaths](#) of secrecy and the [oddness](#) of their rituals invite suspicion. What is it that they get up to in those strange and [gloomy halls](#)? If you are going to make secrecy the basis of a quasireligious pact [at the root](#) of your society, it [is bound to](#) generate suspicion, argues John Dickie, Professor of Italian Studies at University College London and author of *The Craft*, How the Freemasons Made the Modern World. **John Dickie:** This secrecy, right from the beginning, has created suspicion. Already in 1738, within a very short time of [Freemasonry](#) being founded in its modern form in London, the Pope excommunicated all Freemasons. Freemasons are on their way to hell because they were bound to be [heretics](#) or revolutionaries or something. Whatever they were doing, it was no good. And things start to get even more complicated because Masonic secrecy and Masonic brotherhood and [fellowship](#) and ritual actually starts to attract people who are genuinely [up to no good](#), or who are genuinely revolutionaries or genuinely religious

dissidents. They see, “[Gosh](#), this is a really good way to organise ourselves.” So you get in the 19th century, particularly a lot of revolutionary secret societies, such as the [charcoal burners](#) in Italy, the Carbonari, who are modelled on the Freemasons. They’re a kind of [branch](#) of [Freemasonry](#), and they’re dedicated to revolution and the cause of uniting Italy. The Freemason’s Hall near Covent Garden in London. The building offers guided tours, a museum of [Freemasonry](#) and a gift shop.

THE MODEL

Many organisations of very different sorts have modelled their hierarchies and rituals on the Freemasons, as Dickie explains. **John Dickie:** Plenty of other organisations have adopted the same organisational model, like the Sicilian Mafia. The Ku Klux Klan also got Masonic DNA, the Mormon Church, [Church of Jesus Christ of the Latter-day Saints](#), [pinched](#) a lot of its rituals and other things from the Freemasons. The world is full of brotherly societies, whether it be the Rotary Club or the Lions, and there are [tons](#) of them out there, which have basically plagiarised the Masonic organisational model and adapted it a bit. Basically, the trunk of this great family tree of brotherly societies all over the world is [Freemasonry](#). Culture

The Koh-i-Noor: The World’s Most Dangerous Diamond Il Koh-i-Noor è il diamante più ambito e maledetto al mondo. Per secoli vari imperi hanno lottato per cercare di impossessarsi di questa straordinaria gemma. Il suo incorporamento ai gioielli della corona britannica è avvolto in una sanguinosa leggenda. Conor Gleeson , Sarah Davison

CONSPIRACY THEORY

In the 20th century, conspiracy theories that became a component of fascist and Nazi ideologies — with their paranoia about [hidden](#) fraternities controlling the elite — inevitably, if bizarrely, drew Freemasons into their orbit. Dickie talked more about this. **John Dickie:** Right from the beginning, Freemasons attracted suspicion. And [in the aftermath of](#) the French Revolution, that suspicion, largely on the part of conservative Catholic forces

who [abhorred](#) and were confounded by what had happened in the French Revolution, that suspicion of [Freemasonry](#) was transformed into something very modern, uniquely modern, the conspiracy theory, the idea that world affairs are controlled by some secret elite from behind the scenes. And so the Freemasons were the protagonists of the first paranoid conspiracy theory... it was actually a former Jesuit priest who wrote this big, huge five-volume analysis of the French Revolution, saying it was all the fault of the Freemasons. And that idea, the modern conspiracy theory, therefore, was born out of the fear of the Freemasons. That form of conspiracy thinking then got legs. All sorts of conspiracy thinking, you know, the QAnon, the [lizard people](#), [you name it](#), all basically, again, come out of that root of paranoia, which is the fear of the Freemasons. And in the middle of the 19th century, that form of conspiracy thinking about the Freemasons began to affect anti-Semitism and give anti-Semitism, a very ancient form of hatred of Jews, new forms, new tropes, if you like. Whereas previously the Jews were [loathed](#) as the killers of Christ and people who performed strange rituals and as [misers](#), those are very ancient stereotypes, as odious as they are ancient. In the middle of the 19th century, late 19th century, this began to be transformed into a more conspiratorial view of Jews, that they were actually trying to rule the world through a secret conspiracy, through elite financial controls, and in some variants, some [strains](#) of this conspiracy thinking, through bodies like [Freemasonry](#). And that's what this famous, notorious [fake](#) called The Protocols of the [Elders](#) of Zion claimed that Masonic [lodges](#) were actually the tools of Jews trying to control world affairs and manipulate everything from financial markets to communist parties to... [you name it](#).

ANCIENT TO MODERN

The Masons survived the dark days of the 20th century and continued to [thrive](#) as they had for many years. Today they have maintained their rituals and their ancient symbolism, but much of the secrecy has been dispelled. Freemasons' Hall in the centre of Covent Garden, London, is open to visitors and offers guided tours. It is worth taking the time to see the place where [Freemasonry](#) continues to be written on the hearts of its

members, says Dickie. **John Dickie:** They did have a golden age and it was sort of in the 19th century and in the early 20th century. They got a huge boost from recruitment, particularly after the First World War, but also after the Second World War, where people were seeking a substitute for the comradeship of the war and so on and so forth. They are in decline now in most parts of the world, not everywhere, and not uniformly by any means. They're an aging organisation. When I was writing my history of Freemasonry, I took my publisher on a little tour of Freemasons' Hall in Covent Garden, the big building which, contrary to popular belief, is perfectly open to visitors, and you can go around and do a tour and see the museum and exhibitions and all that kind of thing. And it's well worth doing. It's an extraordinary building. But it's also a very creepy building. It does seem like some Martian temple that has been planted in the centre of London, and it feels creepy also. It's got this sort of brown light somehow in it and lots and lots of symbols you don't recognise... and my publisher found it too creepy. He said, "I'm really sorry, I've just got to get out. I'm spooked."

STRUCTURE OF FREEMASONRY

The chart presents a visual map of the traditional structure of Freemasonry, beginning with the three foundational degrees that every member receives and showing how all other Masonic bodies branch out from that core. The degrees, symbols, and ceremonies — presented in a progressive manner — represent "phases of human development, stages of self-knowledge and transformation." In the First Degree, the Entered Apprentice, the individual confronts their "rough stone": their passions, vices, fears, and shadows. It focuses on self-knowledge and the beginning of inner work. In the Second Degree, the Fellow Craft, the initiate studies the laws of the world — art, science, harmony, and the order of the universe. In the Third Degree, the Master Mason, the individual symbolically experiences death and rebirth, echoing central themes of moral reflection and spiritual renewal. At the centre of the chart, the prominent letter 'G' encapsulates core Masonic teachings. Commonly interpreted as representing both Geometry and God, it symbolises the bridge between the material and the spiritual, the scientific

and the divine. If you want to know more about this topic, read the article [Freemasonry](#): The [Craft](#).

Glossary

- **spooked** = spaventare, mettere ansia
- **rough stone** = pietra grezza
- **bind** = legare, unire
- **high-minded** = nobili
- **handshakes** = strette di mano
- **Craft** = arte, mestiere
- **in the aftermath of** = periodo successivo a
- **lizard people** = rettiliani
- **Elders** = savi
- **den** = tana, covo
- **Enlightenment** = Illuminismo
- **oddness** = stranezza
- **fellowship** = fratellanza
- **Freemasonry** = massoneria
- **ruling elites** = élite al potere
- **get annoyed** = irritarsi
- **branch** = branca
- **pinched** = rubacchiare
- **tons** = un sacco
- **boost** = impulso
- **secure** = assicurarsi
- **you name it** = e chi più ne ha più ne metta
- **loathed** = detestare
- **strains** = varianti
- **thrive** = prosperare
- **comradeship** = cameratismo
- **by any means** = per niente
- **it's well worth** = valere la pena
- **halls** = sale, saloni
- **charcoal burners** = carbonai
- **misers** = avari, tirchi
- **lodges** = logge
- **aging** = invecchiata, obsoleta

- **branch out** = diramarsi
- **core** = centro, nucleo
- **gloomy** = cupi, tetri
- **heretics** = eretici
- **up to no good** = tramare qualcosa di losco
- **abhorred** = detestare
- **fake** = falso
- **and so on and so forth** = e così via
- **creepy** = inquietante
- **Gosh** = caspita
- **devil-worshippers** = adoratori del diavolo
- **oaths** = giuramenti
- **at the root** = alla base
- **is bound to** = essere destinato a
- **Church of Jesus Christ of the Latter-day Saints** = Chiesa di Gesù Cristo dei Santi degli Ultimi Giorni